

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

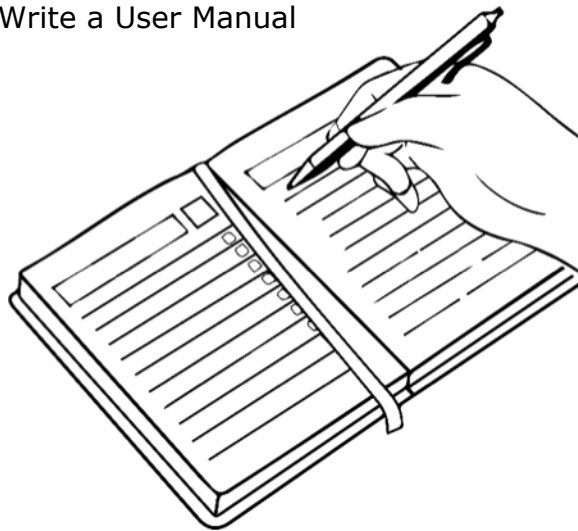
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Let's Start!

Getting Prepared to Write a User Manual



Learning Outcome:

Designs a user manual that fulfills both the IT solution needs and the client requirements.

Understand how to write a good user manual.

Can Do Statements:

- I can explain in a paragraph how to write an effective user manual.
- I can make an outline for a user manual.

Ask your partner:

- Have you ever had a bad experience with manuals? What was it?
- What aspects do you think are important to plan before writing a manual?





Let's Explore!

Listen to a lecture about how to create effective user manuals.



Instructions: Read the text below.

User Manuals

Today, we go on with our last lesson about manuals. Let's go over the basic considerations you may have to keep in mind when creating an effective manual. First, you might need to get out of your own mind. By this, I mean you should think of the person who is going to read the manual. Do not take anything for granted unless you know you're writing for a specialized audience.

You should also have clear the purpose of your manual and let the reader know it. This way you'll avoid wasting users' time. It's important you plan what you're going to write before you just jump to do it. Select the appropriate information and make it easy to understand; not all users comprehend all the technical terms, try to use synonyms and add a glossary if necessary. If you feel you need to explain difficult instructions, do not hesitate and insert images and diagrams, they help you illustrate concepts. Before you decide if it is the final version of your manual, ask someone to read it and be open to feedback. Sometimes we think we're clear, but we might not use the right words or grammatical structures.

Let's move on to the next point, how to write an outline for a user manual. First, you need to choose carefully the parts you consider must be in the manual. Write an introductory page, describing the main components and functions. Write the body of the manual, and remember to read after you're done. This helps you avoid typos and confusing ideas. If you need a graphic, draw a sketch, write the main ideas and move on. Finally, you'll need to add the table of contents and contact information for further questions.





Let's Practice!

I might have some ideas on how writing a user manual.

Instructions: Classify the sentences by writing the number of each sentence in the correct category.

1. Before writing a manual, you might need to get out of your own mind.
2. You might have difficulties to explain some instructions. To solve this, you could insert images and diagrams.
3. You should also have clear the purpose of your manual and let the reader know it.
4. The reader may get confused if you don't clarify the purpose of your manual and let him know it.
5. You need to select the appropriate information and make it easy to understand; not all users comprehend all the technical terms.
6. Some technical terms could be difficult to understand. You might try to use synonyms and add a glossary.
7. When you need to explain difficult instructions, you can insert images and diagrams.

These are speculations on how writing a user manual.	These are not speculations on how writing a user manual.



Let's Practice!

Making a User Manual: Step by Step

Instructions: Write the words to correctly complete the sentences. Use words from the box below.

come across / keep in mind / write down / make use of / go over

1. You should _____ different steps before outlining a manual.
2. You need to _____ all the elements you want to explain.
3. You have to _____ an introductory page, describing the main components and functions.
4. _____ that short and simple texts are better than long and complicated.
5. _____ as many visual aids as you need.





Extension Activity

Writing an Outline of a User Manual

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Choose a product.
- Write an outline of a manual to explain how to use this product.
- Add as many visual as you need.
- Proofread your manual to see if it is correct and complete.
- Compare your work with your classmates.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

- I chose a product I like.
- I write an outline of the manual.
- I use visual aids.
- I proofread my manual for grammar mistakes
- I compare my work with my classmates.

☐	☐
☐	☐
☐	☐
☐	☐
☐	☐



Target Words

- **take something for granted** (expression): to assume someone knows something.
e.g. Do not take anything for granted unless you know you're writing for a specialized audience.
- **typo** (noun): a typing mistake.
e.g. This helps you avoid typos and confusing ideas.
- **waste** (verb): to use inappropriate something.
e.g. This way you'll avoid wasting users' time.
- **go on** (phrasal verb): to continue.
e.g. Today, we go on with our last lesson about manuals.
- **move on** (phrasal verb): to continue.
e.g. Let's move on to the next point, how to write an outline for a user manual.
- **sketch** (noun): a rough drawing or design.
e.g. If you need a graphic, draw a sketch, write the main ideas and move on.



Learning Points

Phrasal Verbs

Phrasal verbs are two-word verbs made out of a verb and a preposition or adverb. **Phrasal verbs** do not follow any specific rule; you just have to memorize them and learn their meanings. They are composed by a **verb** and a **preposition** or **adverb**. There are some phrasal verbs that are separable, this means that you can separate the verb from the preposition or adverb when the action affects directly an object or object pronoun (*me, you, him, her, it, us, them.*)

Example:

Turn off

The system is programmed to **turn off** the updates.

The system is programmed to **turn** the updated **off**.

The system is programmed to **turn it off**. (Correct)

The system is programmed to ~~turn off~~ it. (Incorrect)

Some other phrasal verbs inseparable, so these words need to remain together, they cannot be separated.

Example:

Work on

We are **working on** a new architecture style.

There are thousands of phrasal verbs. Let's check some of them in the next chart:

Phrasal verb	Meaning
Catch up	To become equal or reach the same level
Come across	To find
Drop by	To visit unexpectedly
Drop out	To leave something
Get over	To recover
Get through	To pass through a situation
Get up	To stand up
Go over	To review
Keep up with	To stay at the same level
Look into	To investigate
Make up	To invent, put together or make part of something
Put up with	To tolerate
Run into	To find something accidentally
Show up	To appear
Write down	To take notes
Write off	To consider something as a failure

Examples

- *Today, we go on with our last lesson about manuals.*
- *Let's go over the basic considerations you may have to keep in mind when creating an effective manual.*





Learning Points

Tips to Write an Effective User Manual

These are some important tips to consider when you write a manual.

Before you write a manual you should consider some important tips to help you develop your ideas better.

Pay close attention to the following tips:

1. Don't assume: Not all users know the same things you do, don't take for granted important pieces of information.
2. Plan your purpose: You need to have clear ideas of what you want to explain, otherwise, you'll end up writing about lots of things.
3. Outline it: Before you get to write the content itself, plan what you want to write, create a draft of how your manual will look like.
4. Keep it short: Don't overwhelm users with tons of information, be specific and try to go straight to the point.
5. Keep it simple: Select words carefully, you might need to create a glossary if you too many technical terms.
6. Use visual aids: If you need to illustrate an idea, introduce pictures or diagrams to make sure the readers get your idea.

Examples

- *You should also have clear the purpose of your manual and let the reader know it.*
- *Select the appropriate information and make it easy to understand.*

